

DD Daniel Davies

Starting University in the UK: Study Expectations

Powered by Articulate

A short course for Level 4 students on writing, referencing, independent study, and where to find support

- Welcome: How to use this course
- How writing often works at a UK university
- Referencing and independent study
- A conversation with Amira
- If Amira waits
- If Amira asks now
- Where to find support

Powered by Articulate

Check your learning

Before you go

Powered by Articulate
Powered by Articulate
Powered by Articulate

Lesson 1 of 9

Welcome: How to use this course

DD Daniel Davies

Powered by Articulate

Welcome

Welcome to this short course on starting university study in the UK.

This course is for Level 4 students, including students who have come from another education system, and students who use English as an additional language. That is expected, and it is welcome.

The course takes about 12 to 15 minutes. You can pause and come back. The English is kept plain on purpose.

By the end, you will be able to:

- check what your own module is asking you to do in a written assignment
- use a simple habit for referencing: name your source, and only cite work you have opened
- plan study time between taught classes
- know where to ask for help, and why asking early is a strength

This course was designed by Daniel P Davies, Associate Lecturer at Liverpool John Moores University. He teaches business, and his doctoral research looks at how Level 4 international business students can use feedback and assessment well.

You already bring knowledge and experience with you. This course explains some common expectations in UK university study, so those expectations are not left hidden.

Powered by Articulate
Powered by Articulate
Powered by Articulate

How to use this course

Follow these four steps to get the most from this course.

Powered by Articulate
Powered by Articulate
Powered by Articulate

Step 1

Read the short lessons in order

There are four short lessons after this welcome, then a four-question quiz. Each lesson is written in plain English.

Powered by Articulate
Powered by Articulate
Powered by Articulate

Step 2

Try the questions and the story

You will follow a student called Amira Hassan. Amira is a generic example only. This is not a real student. At each decision, choose an option and read the feedback.

Powered by Articulate
Powered by Articulate
Powered by Articulate

Step 3

Use the buttons if you want to see one path more clearly

After the first decision, two buttons let you jump to a short "what happens if..." lesson. Then a button will bring you back.

Powered by Articulate
Powered by Articulate
Powered by Articulate

Step 4

Check your own handbook

This course uses generic examples. Your real rules, reading lists, and support names are in your module handbook and your student handbook. If you are unsure, ask your tutor.

A note about the examples

Amira Hassan, her assignment, and the advice in the story are generic examples only. They were written for teaching. They are not real student work, and they do not come from a real module.

Your own course may look different. The habits you practise here will still transfer: read the brief, use sources you have actually opened, plan time between classes, and ask for help early.

CONTINUE

Powered by Articulate
Powered by Articulate
Powered by Articulate

How writing often works at a UK university

DD Daniel Davies

Powered by Articulate

There is not only one "correct" way to write

In many UK university modules, a written assignment is not only a test of English grammar. It is also a way to show your thinking.

Lea and Street (1998) showed that writing at university is not one single skill. Different subjects, and even different staff, can expect different things. What counts as a "good" assignment in one module may not be the same in another.

So the first step is practical, and it is also kind to yourself: do not guess. Check what this module is asking you to do.

In many Level 4 business modules, you are often asked to:

- make a clear point, or a clear recommendation
- support that point with evidence
- say what that evidence means, not only repeat it
- write in your own words, and name your sources

Your module may also use a rubric. A rubric is a table or list that describes quality. It tells you what the marker is looking for.

1. Make a clear point	Start a paragraph with the point you want the reader to understand. Then add the evidence. Do not leave the reader to guess your recommendation or your claim.
2. Support the point with evidence	Evidence can be a figure from a case pack, a point from a reading, or a fact you can show. After you give the evidence, add one sentence that says what it means for your point.

Powered by Articulate
Powered by Articulate
Powered by Articulate

3. Use your own words, and name the source

Putting an idea into your own words shows that you have understood it. You still need to name the source. Copying a sentence without a reference is not acceptable.

4. Check this module's brief

Some modules want a report. Some want an essay. Some want a briefing. The heading style, the tone, and the reading list can differ. The brief and the rubric are your guide.

Powered by Articulate

If a phrase in the brief is new to you, such as "critical analysis" or "justified recommendation," ask what it means in this module. That is a strong question, not a weak one.

A Level 4 brief says: "Write a short briefing. Make a justified recommendation, using evidence from the pack." What is the best way to start?

- Write a general essay about the topic, and hope the recommendation becomes clear at the end.
- Read the brief and the rubric, then plan a clear recommendation that you can support with evidence from the pack.
- Copy a model essay from the internet, because all university writing is the same.
- Ignore the pack, and write only from your own opinion.

SUBMIT

Powered by Articulate
Powered by Articulate
Powered by Articulate

Continue to referencing and independent study

Lesson 3 of 9

Referencing and independent study

DD Daniel Davies

Powered by Articulate

Two habits that often surprise new students

This lesson covers two common expectations.

Referencing. A reference is a clear note of the source you used, in the text and in a list at the end. In many business modules, this is an author-date style, sometimes called Harvard. Your handbook will tell you the exact style to use. The idea is simple: a reader should be able to find the same source.

Only cite a source you have actually opened and read. If you cannot open it, do not put it in your list.

Independent study. In many UK modules, class time is only part of the learning. A lecture is a large taught class. A seminar is a smaller class where you are often expected to join in. Independent study is the reading, planning, and practice you do between those classes. This can be different from some previous education systems, where more of the work happened in class. It does not mean you are left alone. It means you are expected to keep going between sessions, and to ask for help if you get stuck.

A simple referencing habit

Powered by Articulate
Powered by Articulate
Powered by Articulate

Step 1

Use the reading list first

Start with the readings your tutor has set, and with sources you can find through the library.

Powered by Articulate
Powered by Articulate
Powered by Articulate

Step 2

Make a note as you read

Write the author, year, title, and the page or figure you may use. Do this while the source is still in front of you.

Powered by Articulate
Powered by Articulate
Powered by Articulate

Step 3

Put the idea in your own words

Then add a short reference in the sentence, such as (Smith, 2023). If you use the writer's exact words, put those words in quotation marks and add a page number, if your style asks for one.

Powered by Articulate
Powered by Articulate
Powered by Articulate

Step 4

Build the reference list as you go

Do not leave this until the last hour. If you cannot open a source, do not include it.

Powered by Articulate
Powered by Articulate
Powered by Articulate

Step 5

Check the style in your handbook

Punctuation details differ. Follow the guide for your module. If you are unsure, ask your tutor or a librarian.

Powered by Articulate

What you might do between classes

Read the set pages, go back to your notes, try a short plan for the assignment, and write down one question for your tutor. You do not have to work for eight hours without a break. Short, regular sessions are often more useful.

How to plan the week

Look at your timetable. Mark the assignment deadline. Then block two or three short study sessions before the next seminar. Put the reading before the class where you can, so the seminar is easier to join.

If the reading is difficult

You do not need to understand every word on the first try. Read the heading, the first sentence of each paragraph, and any conclusion. Note one idea, and one question. Bring that question to class, or to a skills appointment.

If you feel stuck

Stuck is common, especially in a new system. Asking for help early is part of independent study, not a failure of it.

A student finds three references in an online summary. The titles look useful, but the student cannot open the original sources. What should the student do?

- Copy the three references into the assignment, because they look academic.
- Do not cite those unread sources. Use the reading list and the library to find sources the student can actually open and read.
- Leave out all sources, and write "research shows" in front of every claim.

SUBMIT

Powered by Articulate

Continue to Amira's story

Lesson 4 of 9

A conversation with Amira

DD Daniel Davies

Powered by Articulate

Meet Amira

Amira Hassan is a Level 4 business student who has just started a UK university course. Amira is a generic example only. This is not a real student, and this is not a real module.

Her first assignment is a 1,000-word briefing, due in three weeks. The brief asks for a justified recommendation, using a short company pack and at least two academic sources from the reading list.

Amira is a capable student. She is also still learning how this system works. Some phrases in the brief, such as "critical analysis," are new to her. She wants to do well, and she does not want to look unprepared.

In the next blocks, you will choose what Amira should do. After you choose, read the feedback. It is part of the story.

"I think I understand the topic, but I am not sure what they want the briefing to look like. Maybe I should wait until I feel more confident."

Decision 1. Amira does not understand the phrase "critical analysis" in the brief. The first seminar is tomorrow, and her tutor's email is in the handbook. What should Amira do?

- Wait for two weeks, and hope the meaning becomes clear the night before the deadline.
- Send a short, specific email to her tutor, or ask the question in tomorrow's seminar, and keep a note of the answer.
- Copy a classmate's old assignment from a different module, because writing is the same everywhere.

SUBMIT

Powered by Articulate
Powered by Articulate
Powered by Articulate

See one path in more detail

You have just chosen what Amira should do about the unclear phrase. If you want to see one path more clearly, use a button below. Each path is a short extra lesson.

When you have read it, use the button in that lesson to come back here, then continue with Decision 2.

SEE WHAT HAPPENS IF A...

SEE WHAT HAPPENS IF A...

Powered by Articulate

Decision 2. Amira has now read the pack. She also finds a blog post with no author and no date. The blog supports the recommendation she wants to make. What should she do?

- Use the blog as her only source, because it agrees with her view.
- Build the argument from the company pack and from sources on the reading list that she can open through the library. She may mention the blog only if her tutor says a

source of that kind is acceptable, and she can still name it accurately.

Invent two journal article details that look real, so the reference list looks longer.

SUBMIT

Decision 3. The deadline is in two days. Amira feels stuck on the structure of the briefing. What should she do?

Stay silent, skip sleep, and submit anything, because asking for help will look like weakness.

Use the support that is still available: email her tutor with a specific question, and check whether academic skills support, or a librarian, can look at her plan before she writes the final draft.

Paste the brief into a public website and ask it to write the whole assignment, then submit that text as her own.

SUBMIT

Powered by Articulate

Continue to where to find support

Powered by Articulate
Powered by Articulate
Powered by Articulate

Lesson 5 of 9

If Amira waits

DD Daniel Davies

Powered by Articulate

If Amira waits until the week of the deadline

This path is a generic teaching example. It is not a prediction about any real person.

Amira does not ask about "critical analysis." She spends the first two weeks rereading the topic in a general way, but she still has no plan for the briefing.

In the last few days, the deadline feels sudden. She now has to guess what the brief means, find sources, and write, all at once. There is little time left to email her tutor, or to use skills support, and still act on the advice.

The work may still be submitted. It is likely to be more stressful than it needed to be, and the recommendation may still be unclear.

The more useful moment to ask was earlier, when a short answer could still shape her plan.

A short question in week one can save a long night in week three.

RETURN TO AMIRA'S ASS...

Powered by Articulate
Powered by Articulate
Powered by Articulate

If Amira asks now

DD Daniel Davies

Powered by Articulate

If Amira asks a specific question now

This path is a generic teaching example. It is not a prediction about any real person.

Amira sends a short email, or asks in the seminar: "In this briefing, what would critical analysis look like in one paragraph?"

Her tutor explains that, in this module, it means making a recommendation, using pack evidence, and saying what is limited about that evidence.

Amira writes that down. She now has a plan: recommendation first, then evidence, then a limitation, then a final decision. She still has to do the reading and the writing. The difference is that the next two weeks have a shape.

Asking did not make the assignment easier in a dishonest way. It made the expectation visible.

A specific question shows that you are taking the task seriously.

RETURN TO AMIRA'S ASS...

Powered by Articulate
Powered by Articulate
Powered by Articulate

Where to find support

DD Daniel Davies

Powered by Articulate

You do not have to do this alone

Starting university in a new country can be demanding, even when you have chosen it for good reasons. Lillyman and Bennett (2014) argue that, with planning, support, and understanding, the experience can be a positive one, and that support should not start from the idea that international students are a problem.

The names of services differ from university to university. The kinds of help below are common. Look them up in your student handbook, or on your university's website. If you cannot find the right team, ask your tutor or a receptionist, and keep asking until you get the right door.

Powered by Articulate

Your module tutor or seminar leader

This is the first person to ask about the brief, the rubric, or a class you have not understood. A short, specific question is easier to answer than "I do not understand anything."

Powered by Articulate

A personal tutor or academic adviser

Many universities give you a named person for wider academic advice, or for when a problem goes beyond one module. If you have one, introduce yourself early, not only in a crisis.

The library

Librarians can help you find readings, use the databases, and check referencing habits. You do not need to be already confident in order to go.

Academic skills or writing support

Many campuses have a skills team who can talk through structure, referencing, or time planning. They will not usually write the assignment for you. They can help you write it better yourself.

Wellbeing, counselling, or disability support

If you are unwell, very anxious, or you need an adjustment, ask early. These teams exist because students use them. Your handbook will give the local name and contact.

The students' union advice service

Students' unions often have an independent advice service for academic or practical problems. This can be useful if you are not sure where to start.

Powered by Articulate
Powered by Articulate
Powered by Articulate

A checklist you can keep

Powered by Articulate
Powered by Articulate
Powered by Articulate

Step 1

Find your key documents

Save your module handbook, the assignment brief, the rubric, and your timetable in one place.

Powered by Articulate
Powered by Articulate
Powered by Articulate

Step 2

Name one person you can email

Write down your module tutor's contact details, and the name of your personal tutor if you have one.

Powered by Articulate
Powered by Articulate
Powered by Articulate

Step 3

Find two support services

Look up the library, and one other service (skills, wellbeing, or the students' union). Save the link or the room number.

Powered by Articulate
Powered by Articulate
Powered by Articulate

Step 4

Plan two study blocks this week

Add two short sessions to your calendar for reading or planning, not only for attending class.

Powered by Articulate
Powered by Articulate
Powered by Articulate

Step 5

Write one question

If anything in your brief is unclear, write one specific question now, and ask it this week.

Powered by Articulate
Powered by Articulate
Powered by Articulate

Step 6

Check again after week two

If a plan is slipping, ask for help then, not only on the deadline day.

Asking for help early is a professional habit, not a weakness.

Continue to the quiz

Powered by Articulate
Powered by Articulate
Powered by Articulate

Lesson 8 of 9

Check your learning

DD Daniel Davies

This short quiz has four questions. It checks the ideas you have just practised. You can retry it. You need 3 out of 4 to pass. After the quiz, there is a short closing note.

Powered by Articulate
Powered by Articulate
Powered by Articulate

Question

01/04

Lea and Street (1998) are used in this course to support which idea?

- That there is one correct university writing style, which never changes.
- That writing at university is not one single skill, and that expectations can differ from module to module.
- That grammar is the only thing markers care about.
- That students should never ask a tutor about writing.

Powered by Articulate
Powered by Articulate
Powered by Articulate

Question

02/04

What is the best description of independent study, as used in this course?

- You are expected to work completely alone, and never ask for help.
- You are expected to do reading, planning, and practice between taught classes, and to ask for help if you get stuck.
- It only applies in examinations.
- It means the tutor will email you every reading, already summarised, the night before class.

Powered by Articulate
Powered by Articulate
Powered by Articulate

Question

03/04

A student cannot open a journal article that was listed by an online tool. What should the student do?

- Cite the article anyway, so the reference list looks longer.
- Leave that unread source out, and find sources through the reading list or the library that the student can actually open.
- Invent a page number, because the marker will not check.
- Stop using any sources at all.

Powered by Articulate
Powered by Articulate
Powered by Articulate

Question

04/04

Amira is unsure what "critical analysis" means in her briefing. What is the best next step?

- Wait until the night before the deadline, then guess.
- Copy a classmate's assignment from a different module.
- Ask her tutor a specific question, in an email or in a seminar, and keep a note of the answer.
- Ask a public website to write the whole briefing, and submit that text as her own.

Powered by Articulate
Powered by Articulate
Powered by Articulate

Lesson 9 of 9

Before you go

DD Daniel Davies

Take one action this week

You can now:

- check what your own module is asking you to do
- use a simple referencing habit, and only cite sources you have opened
- plan independent study between classes
- find generic forms of support, and ask for help early

Choose one action from the checklist in Lesson 4, and do it this week. If a brief is still unclear, write one specific question for your tutor today.

Thank you for working through this course.

You belong on this course. The aim of these habits is to make the expectations visible, not to test whether you already knew them.

Powered by Articulate
Powered by Articulate
Powered by Articulate

Further reading

These sources informed the course. They are listed mainly for tutors, and for students who want to go further. You do not need to read them in order to complete the activities. Your own handbook is the guide that applies to your work.

- Lea, M. R., & Street, B. V. (1998). Student writing in higher education: An academic literacies approach. Studies in Higher Education, 23(2), 157–172. https://doi.org/10.1080/03075079812331380364
- Lillyman, S., & Bennett, C. (2014). Providing a positive learning experience for international students studying at UK universities: A literature review. Journal of Research in International Education, 13(1), 63–75. https://doi.org/10.1177/1475240914529859

Powered by Articulate
Powered by Articulate
Powered by Articulate